The Case for Dualism

Phil 101 · Day 13

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Where we are

Previously, on 101

Over the last three classes, we saw three arguments that the purely physical story leaves something out.

- Russell: What you're immediately aware of isn't the table, but your sensations of apparently perceiving the table.
- Nagel: No amount of bat neuroscience tells you what it's like to be one.
- Jackson: Mary knew all the physics and still learned something.

Each of them says something is missing. But what *is* this missing thing?

Today

Today we'll look at the natural answer to this question.

Minds aren't physical.

What's missing is the non-physical aspect of minds.

If you're religious, or spiritual, you might call this a soul.

But it doesn't have to be.

Vital Forces

Until not that long ago, i.e., through at least much of the 19th century, a very common view in bio-chemistry was that there was something chemically distinctive about living things.

The label for this missing thing was the **vital force**, and the view was called **vitalism**.

Note here we're talking about *living* things; no one was going around saying plants have souls.

But they did think that the physics of inorganic matter was insufficient to explain how living things worked.

That's not a remotely popular view nowadays, but it's worth keeping in mind as a parallel if you want a non-religious version of what kind of view dualism might be.

The flying man

Back to Ibn Sīnā



Figure 1: Ibn Sīnā (Avicenna)

We met him on Day 10, and I said we'd come back when we asked what kind of thing the self might be.

Time to ask that question!

Our guide

We're not reading Ibn Sīnā in the original; among other things I don't speak the right language.

We're looking at a summary by Peter Adamson, a Notre Dame grad who now works in Munich.

I'm only pausing over this because Adamson is, in my opinion, the best producer of philosophical works written for people who haven't already done a philosophy degree going around.

Podcasts

Adamson's thesis was on Islamic philosophy, so he's a particularly good guide to Ibn Sīnā. But he's most famous for his podcast series:

- A History of Philosophy Without Any Gaps

After he started on this, people pointed out that he was only focussing on work from Europe and West Asia, and this left some quite large gaps. So he now has three more co-authored series:

- A History of Philosophy in India, with Jonardon Ganeri.
- A History of Philosophy in China, with Karyn Lai.
- A History of Africana Philosophy, with Chike Jeffers.

And he has many books from basically the scripts of these. All highly recommended. Indeed, if the only thing you take away from today are "I should look at these podcasts/books", that won't be my worst day lecturing.

Ibn Sīnā's core example

i Adamson

Imagine, he says, that a person is created by God in mid-air, in good condition but with his sight veiled and his limbs outstretched so that he is touching nothing, not even his own body. This person has no memories, having only just been created.

What it’s meant to show

> **Adamson**
>
> The flying man is aware of himself; he knows that he exists. But he is not aware of his body; he doesn’t know that his body exists.

So there is something he knows about himself that he doesn’t know about his body.

Therefore, he isn’t his body.

Note what isn’t argued for

> **i** Adamson
>
> Avicenna does not attempt to *argue* that the flying man would know that he exists. Rather, he takes it as obvious.

Is this a weakness? Probably not; most people think he would know he exists.

iClicker QUIZ

In Adamson's telling, which of these is **not** part of the flying man's situation?

A. His sight is veiled
B. His limbs are held apart so he touches nothing, not even himself
C. He has just been created, and has no memories
D. He has been stripped of his capacity to reason

The trouble with the argument

The big objection

We'll see this again and again in arguments about dualism, so it's important to have it on the table.

Adamson

One can be conscious of a thing without being conscious of everything about it.

Why that is a problem

Compare this argument.

1. I know that *the philosophy 101 lecturer* is **Brian**.
2. I don't know that *the philosophy 101 lecturer* is **the only Australian on the philosophy faculty**.
3. So **Brian** is not **the only Australian on the philosophy faculty**.

The premises could well be true, and the conclusion is actually false. (There are some Australian GSIs, and some Australians on the Cog Sci faculty, but I'm the only Australian *faculty* member in philosophy - at least as long as I keep losing arguments that we should hire more.)

Objects and Descriptions

We tend to know things under descriptions.

You might know something under one description, but not under the other.

It doesn’t follow that the object does not satisfy both descriptions.

I can be both the person who is X, and the person who is Y, even if you know one of those things and not the other.

The thing the flying man exists might be both the flying man himself, and the flying man’s body, even if he knows one of those things and not the other.

What’s left

Adamson thinks something survives anyway.

> **Adamson**
>
> All Avicenna has really done is to throw down a challenge to his materialist opponents: show me how a body could be aware of itself without using sensation to do so.

A challenge is really not a proof, but it is a spur to further research.

Descartes

Six hundred years later

Descartes runs an argument with the same shape, and it is rather widely discussed.

Descartes' most famous book is a very strange work called the *Meditations*, where he imagines a rather long inner monologue, where he tears his knowledge apart and tries to put it back together.

By the end of the *Meditations* he thinks he has established two things he can be certain of: that he exists as a thinking thing, and that God exists and is no deceiver.

The second lets him trust whatever he perceives **clearly and distinctly**.

The real distinction

1. I clearly and distinctly understand my mind as a thing that thinks, but it is no part of my understand of it that it is extended.
2. I clearly and distinctly understand my body as a thing that is extended, but it is no part of my understanding of it that it thinks.
3. Clear and distinct perception can be trusted.
4. So, the two can be separated, at least by God.
5. So my mind is really distinct from my body, and can exist without it.

The same objection, again

The inference to line 4 is the problem. Understanding A without understanding B is a fact about your understanding.

Getting from there to *A and B can come apart* needs a further step.

That is just what we said was the problem with the flying man argument.

Descartes's appeal to God doesn't obviously help here; we would need the further claim that it is no part of *God's* understanding of my mind that it is not extended.

Varieties of dualism

Substance dualism

Berger

Substance dualism proposes that minds are substances that think, feel, and experience, but do not take up space and could exist without bodies.

A substance is something that can exist on its own. This is the view Descartes and Ibn Sīnā are arguing for.

Property dualism

Berger

Property dualism holds that creatures may have distinct mental and physical properties, although they perhaps cannot have mental features without also having physical ones.

There is one kind of stuff. It has two kinds of feature, and one of them isn't physical.

Which one do you get?

The arguments from Nagel, Jackson and Chalmers, if they work, get you **property** dualism. Something about experience isn't captured physically. (Compare the 19th century biological arguments for vitalism; they get you that plants have some properties that rocks lack, but not that plants have a distinct part, a soul, that rocks lack.)

They don't get you a separable soul. They don't get **substance** dualism.

For that you need the flying man or the real distinction, and those arguments are tougher to make work.

Thought and feeling, again

Thinking and feeling

Thinking

Whatever we do with observations of the world and combinations of them. Reasoning, planning, inferring.

Consciousness

There being something it is like, for the thing itself.

I said these were two concepts, not one, and that any link between them needs an argument. Here's one way to link them together.

The grid

	Conscious	**Not conscious**
Thinks	you, right now	?
Doesn’t think	?	a rock

Descartes fills in the two corners and leaves the other two empty. Everything that thinks feels, and everything that feels thinks.

Why he’s entitled to that

If thought and consciousness are both modes of one mental substance, then whatever has either has both. It either has a soul, and thinks and feels, or lacks one, and neither thinks nor feels.

Which means the diagonal is a consequence of **substance** dualism in particular.

Without that, it isn’t clear why we should think everything lives on the diagonal.

A quick question (POLL)

Which of the two empty boxes is really empty?

A. Thinks but isn’t conscious; nothing could be like that
B. Conscious but doesn’t think; nothing could be like that
C. Both. Nothing occupies either
D. Neither. Both have occupants

The occupants

Thinks, not conscious. If Chalmers is right that zombies are possible, then they live in this cell. If humans can do subconscious processing that deserves to be called thought, we can think while we're not feeling things. Droids in sci-fi movies are often presented as living here. Much more contentiously, I wonder how close we are to modern robots, like Waymos, being here.

Conscious, doesn't think. A creature that feels pain and fear and nothing much else. Some animal cognition experts hold that surprisingly few animals genuinely think; they may represent their environment and respond, but so does a non-thinking Roomba. But nobody really denies that cats and dogs feel pain and fear.

The slide

The slide from *it thinks* to *it feels*, and back, is everywhere, especially in what people say about machines.

That slide works in Cartesian metaphysics, where bodies do nothing mental and souls do all the mental stuff. But if you've dropped the Cartesian metaphysics, you need some other reason for it, and there isn't an obvious one lying around.

Animals

Descartes is often reported as holding that animals feel nothing at all, because feeling would require a soul and he denied them one.

Not all interpreters of Descartes agree with this interpretation, but it is pretty widespread.[1]

What's clear is that there's some pressure on his metaphysics to think this. He wants to line up these three things:

1. Has a soul
2. Thinks
3. Feels

[1] John Cottingham, "'A Brute to the Brutes?': Descartes' Treatment of Animals," *Philosophy* 53 (1978).

Going forward

Thursday

We have the case for dualism, and some arguments that still have gaps. (History of philosophy without any gaps does not mean history of philosophical *arguments* that lack gaps.)

Thursday we'll start on the responses to these arguments, and the canonical statement of the most famous response comes from one of Descartes's earliest readers, who also happened to be a princess.